CHAPTER 3

SOCIAL INSTITUTIONS: CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Investigate the institutional dynamics of caste, tribe, and family in India, tracking historical transformations under colonial classification, post-independence land reforms, Sanskritisation, dominant caste formation, tribal classification, and kinship restructuring.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Caste as a Segmental and Hierarchical Structure:** Classical caste is characterized by endogamy, hereditary occupation, segmental division, ritual hierarchy of purity and pollution, and civil or religious disabilities; British decennial censuses (under Herbert Risley) formalized and rigidified these fluid identities.

• **Sanskritisation and Dominant Caste Dynamics:** M.N. Srinivas introduced Sanskritisation to describe lower castes adopting customs, rituals, and dietary habits of upper castes for positional mobility; he formulated the concept of Dominant Caste to designate castes wielding substantial landownership, numerical strength, and local political power.

• **Tribal Identity: Isolation versus Integration:** Tribes (Adivasis) have been classified by permanent traits (region, language) and acquired traits (livelihood, Hinduisation); the historical debate pitted isolationists (Verrier Elwin advocating cultural preservation) against integrationists (G.S. Ghurye viewing tribes as backward Hindus).

• **Family and Kinship Transformations:** The traditional joint family is undergoing structural differentiation toward nuclear households under urbanization and occupational mobility, though emotional and ritual kinship networks remain resilient across patrilineal and matrilineal systems.

ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Caste Institution Matrix} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Varna (4 Classical Orders)} \longleftrightarrow \text{Jati (Endogamous Regional Groups)}$$

Dual Structural Model of Indian Social Stratification

$$\text{Dominant Caste (M.N. Srinivas)} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Substantial Landholding} + \text{Numerical Dominance} + \text{Intermediate Ritual Status}$$

Three Intersecting Pillars of Rural Dominance

$$\text{Tribal Trait Typology} \rightarrow \{\text{Permanent: Ecological Zone and Language}, \quad \text{Acquired: Agrarian Livelihood and State Integration}\}$$

Comprehensive Sociological Framework for Tribal Communities

$$\text{Lineage Descent Dualism} \rightarrow \{\text{Patrilineal: Descent via Father}, \quad \text{Matrilineal: Descent via Mother (e.g. Khasi, Garo)}\}$$

Bifurcated Kinship Descent and Inheritance Systems

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Sanskritisation leads only to positional change within the caste hierarchy for a specific group; it does not lead to structural change of the caste system as a whole.

• **Alert:** Never equate Varna with Jati; Varna is a pan-Indian four-fold scriptural classification, whereas Jati consists of thousands of localized, endogamous socio-occupational groups.

• **Alert:** Nuclear family proliferation does not indicate the death of the joint family; Indian families often maintain extended economic assistance, common ritual duties, and emotional bonds across separate physical households.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Distinguish between Varna and Jati. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Varna:** A pan-Indian, scriptural four-fold classification dividing society into Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, and Shudra (with untouchables historically placed outside as Avarna). **[1 Mark]**

• **Jati:** An empirical, localized, and complex institution consisting of thousands of strictly endogamous, hereditary occupational groups specific to distinct linguistic regions. **[1 Mark]**

2. Describe any three traditional characteristics of the caste system as identified by G.S. Ghurye. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Segmental Division of Society:** Caste membership is determined strictly by birth, dividing society into independent, self-regulating compartments with internal caste panchayats. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Strict Endogamy:** Individuals are strictly mandated to marry only within their own caste group, prohibiting inter-caste unions to maintain social closure. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Purity and Pollution:** Social relations, commensality (food sharing), and physical contact are regulated by ritual notions of purity and pollution, determining social hierarchy and distance. **[1 Mark]**

3. How did British colonial policies and the decennial census of 1901 rigidify the caste system in India? [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Census Classification under Herbert Risley:** The 1901 decennial census attempted to officially record and rank every single caste in an exact hierarchical order based on social precedence. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Rise of Caste Petitions:** Hundreds of caste associations submitted petitions and mythological claims to census commissioners demanding higher ranking, thereby rigidifying fluid local hierarchies. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Codification and Land Settlements:** Colonial courts codified customary caste laws regarding marriage and inheritance, turning flexible traditional practices into rigid statutory provisions. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain M.N. Srinivas's concept of 'Dominant Caste'. Give two examples of dominant castes in India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** A concept coined by M.N. Srinivas to describe an intermediate or peasant caste that wields decisive socioeconomic and political power in a given rural locality or region. **[1 Mark]**

• **Three Vital Attributes:**
- Substantial control over arable agricultural land through ownership rights.
- Sizable numerical strength in the local population.
- Intermediate ritual status in the caste hierarchy with modern political leverage. **[2 Marks]**

• **Examples:** The Jats in Haryana and Western Uttar Pradesh, the Yadavs in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, the Vokkaligas and Lingayats in Karnataka, and the Kammas and Reddys in Andhra Pradesh. **[1 Mark]**

5. Critically evaluate the debate on tribes between Verrier Elwin (isolationism) and G.S. Ghurye (integrationism). [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Verrier Elwin (Isolationist View):** Argued that tribes were being exploited, dispossessed of land, and culturally ruined by non-tribal moneylenders and traders; advocated state protection in national parks and preservation of indigenous culture. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **G.S. Ghurye (Integrationist View):** Maintained that tribes were not distinct aboriginal isolates but 'imperfectly integrated backward Hindus' who had assimilated through historical cultural contact, advocating their full integration into mainstream national development. **[1.5 Marks]**

6. What is meant by Sanskritisation? Highlight any two major limitations or criticisms of this process. **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** A concept coined by M.N. Srinivas referring to the process by which a low or middle Hindu caste, tribe, or other group changes its customs, rituals, ideology, and way of life in the direction of a high, twice-born (dwija) caste. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Two Major Criticisms:**
- It leads only to positional mobility for an individual caste without altering or abolishing the structural inequality of the caste hierarchy.
- Dalit thinkers criticize it for accepting upper-caste cultural hegemony and devaluing rich, egalitarian Dalit labour and traditions. **[1.5 Marks]**

7. Examine the major structural and functional changes occurring in the Indian family institution in contemporary times. **[Score: 5 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Shift from Joint to Nuclear Households:** Growing urban migration, industrial employment, and housing constraints in metropolitan cities have led to a sharp increase in nuclear residential family units. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Continuity of Extended Kinship Ties:** While physical living arrangements may be nuclear, families retain joint characteristics through financial mutual aid, emotional support, and shared celebration of life-cycle rituals. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Changing Gender Roles and Authority:** Increased female literacy, economic independence of women, and dual-income households are democratizing family decision-making and weakening traditional patriarchal authority. **[1 Mark]**

• **Impact on Care of the Elderly:** The erosion of multi-generational households has created new challenges for elderly care, necessitating old-age care homes and institutional support systems. **[1 Mark]**